Chapter Ninety-Two

Perpetual Slavery

Between 1415 and 1455,
the Portuguese send slave ships to West Africa,
and the pope gives them permission for conquest

DECADES BEFORE, the war between France and England had thrust tendrils into the Spanish peninsula; those tendrils had rooted, and now were growing thorny fruit of their own.

The former John of Aviz was now John I of Portugal, and John of Gaunt's English daughter Philippa was his queen. In Castile, the nine-year-old great-grandson of Enrique of Trastámara ruled as John II. After the Portuguese victory at Aljubarrota, the two countries had remained at war for another twenty-six years; not until October 1411 was a truce finally reached.

Now Castile and Portugal were carrying on a new struggle: for trade, for wealth, and for the islands that lay in the Atlantic to the west.

So far, Castile was winning. In 1402, the French adventurer Jean de Béthencourt had landed in the Canary Islands "with the view of conquering the islands, and bringing the people to the Christian faith." He hoped for glory, chivalric deeds of daring, and plenty of loot; his expedition, chronicled by two Franciscan priests who accompanied it, immediately captured some of the inhabitants, an African tribal people known as the Guanches, and brought them back to the port of Cadiz to sell as slaves.